

AI and energy production

Posted by u/ElderberryNo9107 • • 0 points • 3 comments

The energy that AI uses has increased significantly in the past five years for pretty obvious reasons. Most of it comes from unsustainable sources.

(<https://e360.yale.edu/features/artificial-intelligence-climate-energy-emissions>)

Some technoskeptics have used this as an argument for pausing / removing AI and stagnating tech at some past level (most people with this view say the 1980s or 1990s).

I'm sympathetic to that view, but I'm wondering what the pro-tech alternative is? As AI use grows it will continue to demand more power, even with algorithmic improvements. Where do we get the energy (without tapping into fossil fuel excess and doing more environmental harm)?

Comments

u/Peach-555 • 1 points • 2025-01-07 12:46 UTC

I should put my cards on the table and say that I think it is a good idea to slow down/pause AI until safety research catches up, and to avoid any racing conditions. My concern is human extinction.

But setting that concern aside since you are asking about the environment.

A.I progress is likely the best thing to happen to the environment as it is used to improve on materials/research that helps out renewable energy and even adjacent stuff like capturing carbon or some more direct form of climate control that we have not even thought up that is not some variation of throwing sulfur into the atmosphere.

The more urgent climate change is, the more urgent A.I becomes as a side effect of its potential to help solve the issue, because humans alone are clearly struggling.

There are non-technological solutions to climate change, but its mostly about lowering the amount of people on earth and the living standard, ie, minimal traveling, mineral material consumption, minimal energy use, bleak future.

But, assuming that AI can't help with the climate, it is still 100% feasible to fill all the demand for AI with renewable energy, and if there is a political will for it, the economical output of AI itself can be used to subsidize energy production of the environmentally friendly kind.

u/ElderberryNo9107 • 0 points • 2025-01-07 13:05 UTC

This is a really good perspective! And for what it's worth, I also support a pause/slowdown on AI for safety. I'm concerned with the extinction of sentient life on Earth (not just humans) and the creation of dystopias that could cause intense suffering.

I'm wondering how you feel about narrow-assistive (no AGI potential) vs. general-autonomous (AGI potential) AI development? I don't see any benefit of AGI to justify the existential and suffering risks it brings.

u/Peach-555 • 2 points • 2025-01-07 13:58 UTC

(I tried sending a comment, but I looks like it maybe got bugged out)

Short summary.

I agree, generality is the danger. Powerful narrow AI is both safe and useful.

I am a big supporter of narrow AI, and think we can improve on that and get great benefits, without having the downsides of the risk from generality.